



Getting Into Top Universities: *Tips From Successful Students*

Advice from students across the globe who were accepted to world-leading US and UK universities during the 2021-2022 admissions cycle!



A CRIMSON EDUCATION PUBLICATION

Featured Students

- Georgia Institute of Technology - Darsh (India 🇮🇳)
- New York University - Daphne (Hong Kong 🇮🇪)
- Columbia University - Anuar (Kazakhstan 🇰🇿)
- University of Oxford - Elise (France 🇫🇷)
- Stanford University - Fara (UK 🇬🇧)
- Stanford - Aryan (UAE 🇦🇪)
- Dartmouth, Cornell, Princeton, Columbia, and UPenn - Francesco (UK 🇬🇧)
- University of Oxford - Nanditha (UAE 🇦🇪)
- Barnard College of Columbia University - Sophia (UAE 🇦🇪)
- Rice University - Lavinia (Australia 🇦🇺)
- University of Cambridge - Chloe (New Zealand 🇳🇿)
- Brown University - Ethan (South Korea 🇰🇷)
- University of California, Los Angeles - Eva (Kazakhstan 🇰🇿)
- University of Chicago - Antônio (Brazil 🇧🇷)
- Duke University - Wanhley (Brazil 🇧🇷)
- Duke University - J'Adore (New Zealand 🇳🇿)
- Stanford University - Ashley (US 🇺🇸)
- University of Chicago - Esther (Taiwan 🇹🇼)
- Imperial College London - Zelin (New Zealand 🇳🇿)
- University of Oxford - David (UK 🇬🇧)
- University of Oxford - Albert* (Australia 🇦🇺)
- Brown University - Brian* (Taiwan 🇹🇼)
- Johns Hopkins University - Liam* (Taiwan 🇹🇼)
- New York University - Amira (Kazakhstan 🇰🇿)
- Stanford University - Nohn Jinna (Thailand 🇹🇭)
- University College London - Ang Ang (Thailand 🇹🇭)
- University of New South Wales - Napat (Thailand 🇹🇭)

**Students' names have been changed at their request.
Some excerpts in this booklet have been edited for clarity and context.*



First-Hand Advice From Successful Top University Admits

A collection of tips, advice, and inspiration to help you on your application journey — from students who have done it themselves!

Getting into a prestigious university in the US or UK is a dream for many students, but the competitive application process can seem impossible at first. Whenever it feels overwhelming, remember that you are not alone! Not so long ago, these successful university admits were in the same boat as you. With a little help from our students who have recently walked the same path you're on, getting accepted to your dream school can become a reality for you too!

As you embark on your college application journey, this booklet aims to equip you with words of

wisdom from students who have endured the ups and downs of the 2021-2022 application process — bringing a fresh perspective to help you succeed.

With the support of their Crimson teams, these students have overcome all manner of obstacles to craft successful applications that earned them acceptance letters from multiple top universities.

For students looking to follow in their footsteps, we've compiled advice from 29 successful students to help you along the way!





Don't be afraid.

This process might seem challenging but if you are calm at every step and are confident in your ability you will achieve what you work for.

Secondly, don't do any activities for the sole purpose that it would look good on a college application.

Continue doing what you love and try impacting as many people as you can through that. Even if you have 2-3 strong extracurriculars but have achieved some great accomplishments in them, you do not need to worry at all.

Manage your time effectively and try to strike a balance between your academics, social life and college application — all of these are equally important.

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Darsh





Focus on your best-fit university instead of the highest-ranked university.

School ranking is usually the first thing students search for when they think about their dream university. Although ranking is important, it was not the most crucial factor for creating my university list as I care a lot about the school culture. When I was doing my research, I attended a lot of information sessions hosted by universities' admissions officers. This is a good chance to get your questions answered by an authoritative figure in the university, so you don't need to spend time searching on Google for answers that may not be correct. What's more, you might leave a good impression by asking questions and increase your chances of getting into the university when they review your application.

Dream Big.

Although I'm not the brightest student at school with straight-A grades and impressive awards, I am still a competitive candidate among other top university applicants. Don't be too humble when it comes to your accomplishments. Own up to them because most likely they're pretty amazing and they really do strengthen your application. If you think an activity or idea doesn't seem good enough compared to other people, just know that your accomplishments make up who you are!

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Daphne



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Start early.

Don't repeat my mistake and leave 20+ essays until one month before the deadline; it will save you and your Essay Mentor a lot of stress.

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Anuar



Getting into the right university can be challenging if you don't know where to begin. To help you get started, we've created a [US Admissions Calculator](#) and [UK Admissions Calculator](#) that generates a list of recommended universities based on your interests and academic standing.





Begin preparations in advance

and be regular in your work, especially for the personal statement as you will write multiple drafts. Also, you should have confidence in yourself, especially during the interviews: they will appreciate it if you appear relaxed as though you are having a normal conversation. Do not let your insecurities and fears stop you from reaching high.

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Elise





Stop trying to compete with expectations of what your application should look like and just focus on being the best version of yourself.

Wherever you go, you will find that happiness and you'll find your community. So I would say don't lose yourself in the process because it's very easy to do that.

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Fara

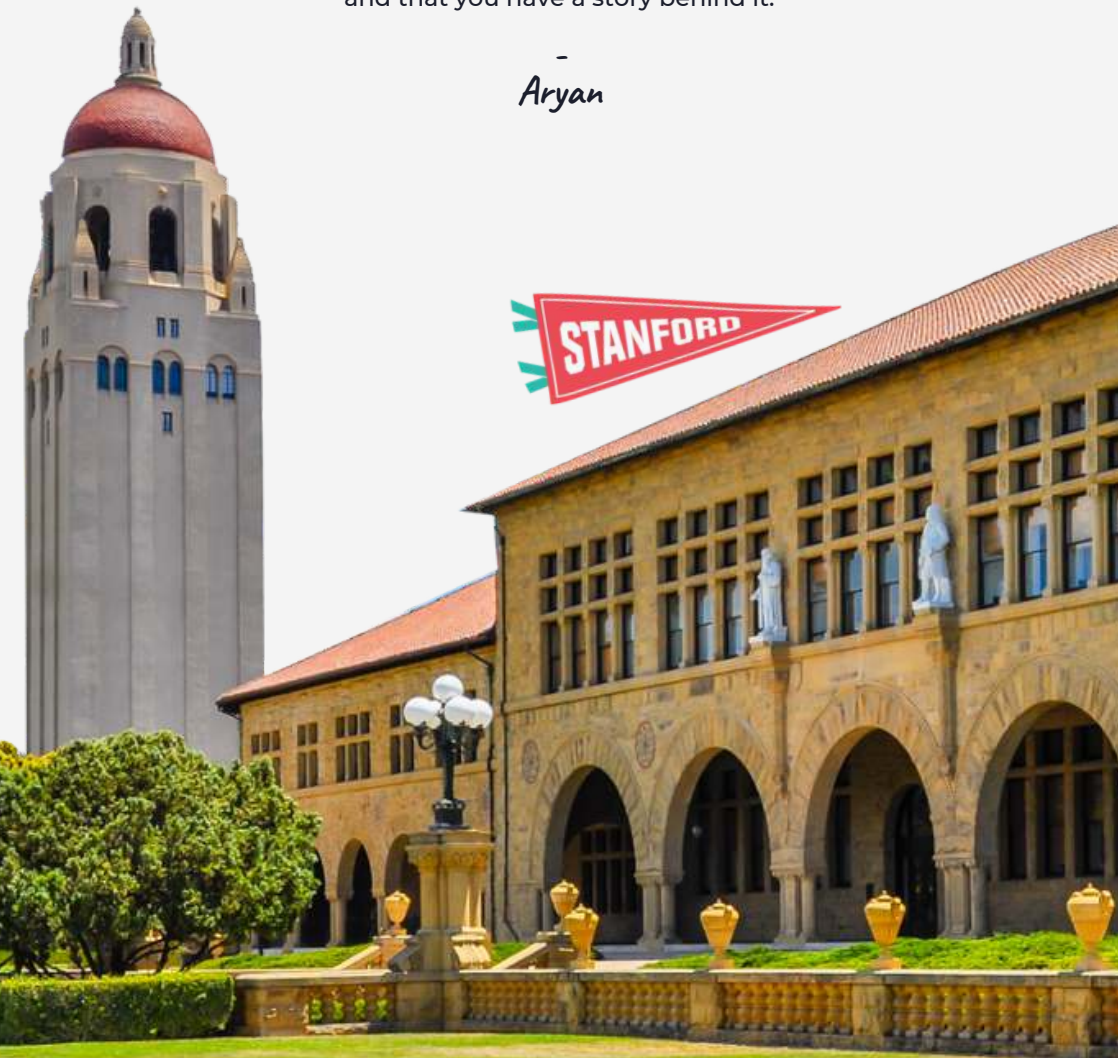




***Admission officers love applicants who
can convey their passion!***

In the end, you have to sum up three years of hard work into three minutes of writing for the admission officer to read. So make sure that anything you do is truly meaningful to you and that you have a story behind it.

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Aryan





I would highly advise using Crimson to help get into their dream university.

Keep researching and start early so that you can get a good idea of what they like and don't like. If they can they should go visit the universities that they are interested in as this is vital. Originally I thought Yale was my top university. After going on an official visit I figured out that actually it wasn't the best place for me after all.

Younger students should ask lots of questions to lots of people, inside the Crimson network and outside of it.

Francesco



Crimson can help you identify your strengths and find your academic passions [REDACTED] with one of our expert Academic Advisors, who can answer all your questions and help get you started on the path to success.



Do not underestimate the importance of research.

It's never too early to start looking into ideas or courses or activities to improve your skill set. A lot of students try to do too much in too little time, and end up stressed and burnt out. Thorough research and proper pacing helps the admissions process in unimaginable ways. For me, this is where Crimson came in. They helped me set deadlines that required me to work hard but that were simultaneously achievable without overexerting myself.

Do what's right for you.

Just because people you know went to a certain university or did a certain course doesn't mean you need to. University and subject choices are always about finding out what makes you tick as a person. What makes you 'you'? How can you channel that into a potential career or a field with scope, and what university offers you the best opportunities to do that? These are some questions to try and answer when making this choice. Analyze your interests and strengths, find an arena where they align, and then look for a university that has an environment conducive to your best interests. Instead of trying to fit yourself into an idea or a stereotype of a student that would fit a university, find a university that suits you.

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Nanditha



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Start the application process early.

Open up to people and you will have people looking out for you, and that will help you in the long run.

I've always been independent and dealt with issues on my own. When I was going through more difficult stuff it was a big burden. Once I was open and vulnerable with my teachers, they had a better understanding of my situation and aspirations — you feel understood, and that takes a lot of pressure off of you.

—
Sophia





Do what you love.

Study the subjects you're most passionate about, pursue extracurricular activities which you'll excitedly get out of bed for (even if it's 4am rowing practice), and write essays which spark joy (thanks Marie Kondo!).

Apply to the university which fits you personally, not necessarily the most prestigious.

I found creating a checklist of all the qualities I wanted in a university and comparing these to my shortlist extremely helpful!

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Lavinia





One piece of advice I would like to give is to spend less time thinking and more time doing.

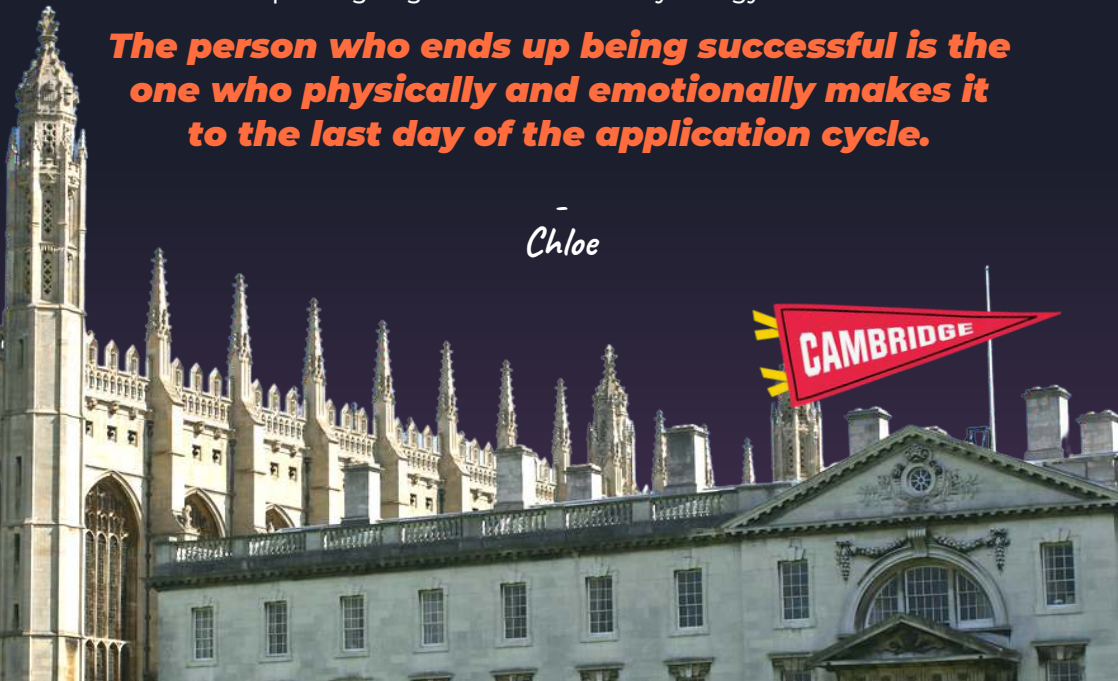
While it is important to plan ahead and strategise, the final years of high school are too intense and filled with unexpected events for any plan you make to work out perfectly. Ultimately, all you can do is try your best to stick to the plan and put in the necessary time and effort to write essays, study for tests, and prepare for interviews.

Another piece of advice that I would like to give is for you to find something that can make you relax, and also to consistently exercise.

For me, I found that going for an hour-long run or a walk every day really helped me relieve stress and kept me healthy. I also think that listening to music kept me sane and allowed me to disassociate from reality and really relax. Finding these methods which removed me from whatever predicament I was in kept me going and maintained my energy and motivation.

The person who ends up being successful is the one who physically and emotionally makes it to the last day of the application cycle.

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Chloe



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When you find what you're passionate about, go with that all the way in and explore everything you can with it.

Everyone gets into college in different ways and that's really important to know because it just means that you should find your passion.

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Ethan





***Don't stress it, keep on working hard
and it will pay off.***

I remember starting to think about university when I was just 12 years old. Each coming year, I kept thinking, “oh no, university is so close and I don’t know what to do”. Younger students should start thinking about university, but they must remember that as long they are pursuing a passion, it will all work out in the best way. One more thing I’d suggest doing is starting to look into universities that offer interesting programs. Reach out to students at the specific university and ask what aspect of their application they think got them in. In addition, it was very helpful for me to read other students’ supplemental essays, provided by Crimson.

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Eva



Are you struggling to write your supplemental essays? Download our eBook to learn everything you need to know about how to approach the US supplemental essays or connect with a [Crimson Essay Mentor](#) to map out your essays well in advance!

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***Anything is possible, it just depends on
how much you are willing to sacrifice.***

The easiest way to succeed in life is to study.

—
Antônio





Try to be your true self — don't pretend to be something you are not.

The most interesting thing about you is the background that you have.

Focus on the process, not the results.

Not just with your essays or your application, but in life.

As an entrepreneur, something I've learned that's very important is:

the ideas and enterprises you can have are countless, but the people that you meet are very few and they're the most important things which you cannot replace.

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Wanghley





You have to make sacrifices if you want to live your dream. If you don't, your dream becomes a sacrifice.

In saying that, I don't think any dream is worth sacrificing your mental health and overall well-being for. At the end of the day you want to be doing what makes YOU happy and not the people around you.

If your well-being is declining and becoming a bigger cost than it should be, then I truly think that becomes your first priority. Ultimately, if you want your dream that badly you want to be at your best when you prepare for it. This is why self-care is so important along that journey because you can't give anything to the things that you're passionate about if there is nothing in you to give.

You don't need to go to a "prestigious" school to make an impact in this world. You're very much capable of doing that on your own.

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J'Adore





Going into the application process, I heard a lot of people tell me to be myself and be who you are in your essay. While this may be harder than it seems, I think it's the most important part of the college applications

Think about what you want to show to the admissions officers and the change you hope to bring.

This takes some introspection in regards to what you want to do... I think it's important to know what you enjoy and know what aspects of yourself that you want to present.

Working with Crimson and the mentors and forming those relationships and showing them who you are so they can help you be your most authentic self in your essays and show colleges who you really are. If you're authentic, it will just show.

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Ashley



Need help with writing your university application essays? Our team of essay review experts are eager to read what you have so far and help you make improvements to submit the best essay possible. [Learn more](#) about Crimson's essay review services and read successful US and UK applicants' submissions!



Find time for extracurriculars, even if they're small.

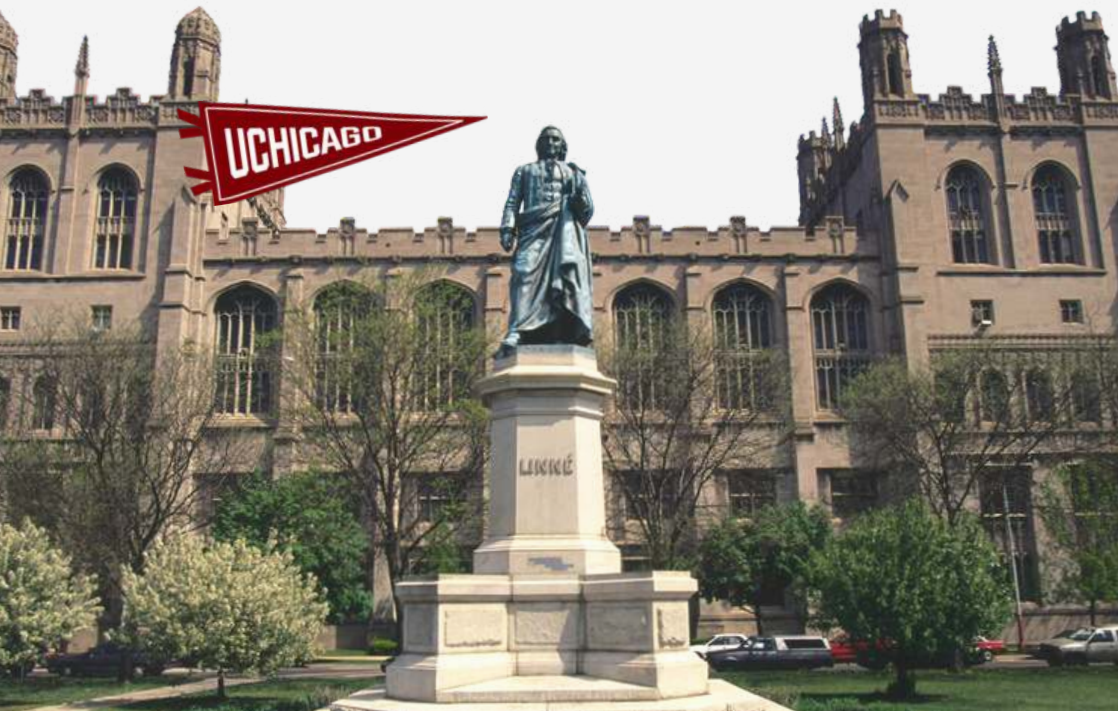
Esther always knew she was an academic-oriented person, and felt pressured to design a big extracurricular project, but understanding her competitive edge, she leaned into scholastic extracurriculars which fit better into her schedule.

As for UChicago hopefuls:

Be unique in your essay and be clear about what you're passionate about.

You don't have to write about your own story in supplementary essays, just show what you love.

-
Esther





Although universities consider the school grades as just one aspect of the whole admission process, having strong A-Level grades will still help a lot.

However, instead of just memorizing everything to get good grades, you should aim to fully understand everything in the curriculum. This will make your life a lot easier!

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Zelin





For any good application, always start making moves as early as those ideas begin to develop.

Start researching your university options, and for Oxbridge make a list of your top three colleges a year before you apply then see if the list changes. And make an in-person visit to the university to understand where you might be living. The earlier you start, the more certain and well committed you can be when applying to your universities of choice.

For Oxbridge specifically, it is so important to make sure that you are truly set on what you want to learn and that it is something you will genuinely be interested in.

This means that you enjoy reading up on the subject of interest or researching certain areas, not just in class or during the year of your application. Start working on a project or entering national competitions that showcase your willingness to go beyond because you're curious, and not just for your application. A candidate who is genuinely interested and invested in their subject will stand out more than someone who only does it for their application.

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David



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Work through things one at a time.

If you put your head down and focus on the little things, the bigger successes will come naturally. You stress less, too, if you aren't always thinking about the statistics. I'm most proud of getting in, of course.

-
Albert





Start searching for your dream schools as early as sophomore or junior year.

don't wait until somebody hands you YOUR own school list.

Don't hesitate to write what's on your mind while planning for essays and don't let concerns about what admissions officers would like to read obscure your passion!

For example, I wrote about biking without a map in downtown (i.e. traveling blindly while running out of time to meet a friend) for a "what brings you joy" essay.

Use your interests as a starting point to showcase your personality in your essays.

Perhaps you hand-made a notebook to use as a diary, or created a gadget using cardboard that fulfills daily tasks for you, or possessed a splendid collection of stamps, postcards, or candy wrappers — probe your memory for something really cool that happened and write about it!

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Brian





Enjoy high school.

This is the last stage of life where things are still structured for you. There were times when I decided to forgo many social activities to study instead. Don't bring extra stress to yourself. You are in good hands: find a balance between building a good college profile and letting loose!

-
Liam





***Do what you love, and never
listen to others.***

On your path, you will meet a lot of people that will try to discourage you from pursuing your dreams. Do not listen to them. Don't do something just because "it will help you when applying to universities", do things because you truly love them.

-
Amira



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Don't stress out too much. Just relax.

Taking a break and having a good night's sleep will help you become more productive. Also, when you write your personal essays, you want to be creative and stressing out doesn't give you that creativity. A lot of problems are fun — it's supposed to be fun. Those essays allow you to explore yourself as well.

—
Nohn Jinna





Grades are not enough. There will always be students that have higher or better grades than you; however, those students may not get in if they do not show or convey to the admissions officer their personality. Especially through essays,

please don't use essays to write about how smart you are. Instead, be authentic and write about who you are and what you like.

I wrote about skincare and goat milk. I also mentioned Blackpink and how much my sister likes them.

Having a passion project is also very important

because it will make you outstanding. A lot of students are very involved in their school community, but other students who apply are also doing that. This is where the passion project comes in. The project will show universities that you don't only take the opportunities given to you, but you're also creating your own opportunities.

My last advice is don't get bummed out when you get rejected from your dream university

because sometimes your personality just doesn't match with what a university is looking for and it really is fine. It's helpful to keep positive and open. Ultimately, you will end up where you belong and where you'll be happy.

Ang Ang





Keep your options open and diverse.

Initially, I didn't expect myself to apply for Australian medical schools. Also, start preparation early, the last minute preparation does not work. Finally, in ensuring a smoother and more successful application route, having a decent planning and organizational skills are extremely pivotal.

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Napat



Ready to start your journey to a top US or UK university?

We hope the collection of advice in this booklet provides you with a source of inspiration as you tackle your own college applications! Keep this booklet handy throughout your own process, and you're sure to find helpful tips to come back to at any point on your journey.

These students didn't do it alone, and you don't have to either.

Crimson students are up to 6x more likely to gain admission to top universities than those who apply alone. When it comes to achieving your university admissions dream, personalized support makes all the difference.

Whether you need help with university selection and application strategy, test preparation, essay support, extracurricular mentoring, or interview practice — we can assist you every step of the way.

So what are you waiting for?

Schedule a free one-on-one consultation with an Academic Advisor today. No matter what stage you are at in the application process, our Crimson experts are ready to help!





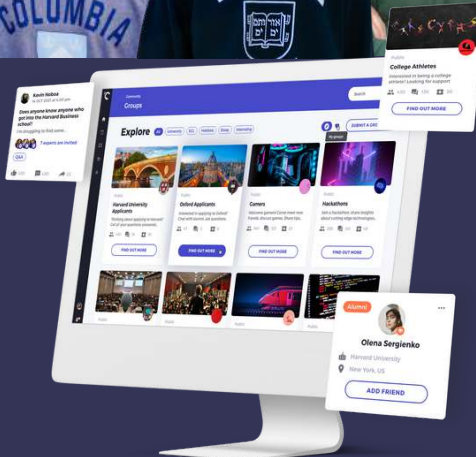
Make your dream possible with **Crimson Education**



Who We Are

Crimson Education is an education consulting company that helps students around the world get into their best-fit universities by creating personalized teams comprised of the top tutors, mentors, and admissions experts.

Our one-on-one sessions ensure that Crimson students get the support they need to stand out in today's highly competitive college admissions race.



Our Services

Crimson's bespoke services help you to achieve your educational aims.



Admissions Consulting



Career and Mentoring



Standardized Test Tutoring



Extracurricular and Leadership



Merit & Need Based Scholarships



Sports Recruitment

Our Results

514+

Offers to the Ivy league

176+

Offers to Oxford and Cambridge

3000+

Offers to US Top 50 universities

1500+

Offers to the UK Top 10 universities



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Crimsoneducation

Why Crimson?



Our Network

2400+

expert tutors,
mentors, and strategists
located around the world



The Crimson Team includes alumni
from top 25 US & UK universities in
over 20 offices around the world



Our elite board of advisors and
sponsors include prestigious influencers
at the top of their chosen industry

Our Methodology

One-On-One Mentoring

We provide our students with personalized one-on-one programs, with the best tutors and mentors from around the world. Our advice is tailored for each individual student!

Roadmaps

Each student will receive a fully-personalized program with a roadmap that outlines every detail of the college admission process.

Resources

We believe in giving students and parents around the world access to vital information. We have the largest YouTube channel of any educational company that depicts college life and answers all of your big questions!

Our Technology

Crimson App

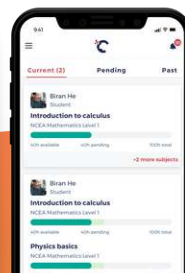
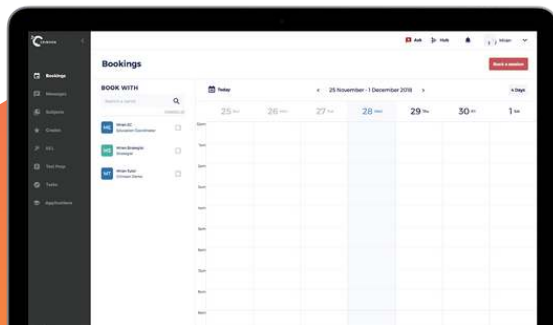
Each Crimson student is onboarded to our mobile & web app, where students can book sessions and view their tailored timetable of customized tasks.

Video Based

Crimson students are able to connect anywhere in the world with their team through our video-based mentoring.

Personality Test

We utilize psychometrics to pair each student with a team that is optimized to his/her interests and learning style! Our test was developed from one of the most well-known data scientists in the world, Galen Buckwalter.



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